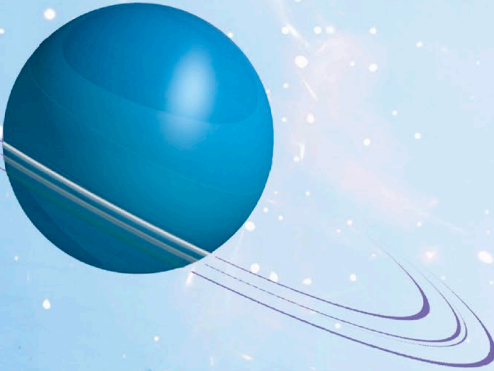




“Black holes are stranger than anything dreamed up by science fiction writers, but they are firmly matters of science fact.”

Stephen Hawking, 2008

and the theory of the infinitely small (quantum mechanics), he produced a significant clue in modern physics' ongoing quest to find a single, unified "theory of everything" to explain the nature of the Universe.

Fame beckons

In 1979, Hawking was appointed Lucasian Professor of Mathematics at Cambridge University, a post he held until 2009. Undeterred by his disabilities, he continued to research black holes and received many accolades and high honors for this and other contributions to physics. He also wrote several popular science books, including *A Brief History of Time*, which was a runaway success and made him a household name. In his final years, he traveled widely, giving public lectures about his work to captivated audiences.

CALCULATED THAT TIME, SPACE, ENERGY, AND MATTER BEGAN FROM A SINGLE DENSE POINT OF ENERGY—A SINGULARITY

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